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LESSON PLAN: “WHAT WOULD YOU DO?”

Integration of Karen Refugees in America

- **Unit:** Intercultural Connection, Acculturation, and Communication in the U.S.
(Lesson 2 of 3)
- **Target Students:** First-year Japanese University Students (Intermediate L2, intensive English program preparing for study abroad)
- **Class Size:** 15 to 20 students
- **Class Length:** 90 Minutes

LESSON IN BRIEF

- **1. Warm-Up: "What is Real Connection?" Board Walk (10 min):** As students enter, four distinct images are projected on the screen to engage them immediately. In pairs, students write four connection-themed words (*Community, Connection, Alone, Confused*) on color-coded sticky notes and walk up to the front to post them directly onto the matching pictures on the board.
- **2. Framing & WALT Goals (5 min):** The teacher presents the lesson goals, framing the class around 100% English use, empathy, and problem-solving, connecting these skills to the students' upcoming study abroad and Japan's growing multicultural society.
- **3. "Would You Leave Japan?" Decision Game (20 min):** In groups of four, learners analyze four relocation scenarios (*Education, Natural Disaster, Job, War*) and vote by distributing ten paper clips across labeled cups. Teams tally their votes, take two minutes to prepare a speaker, and deliver a 45-second explanation speech selected by the Hot Potato routine.
- **4. Input: Karen Background, Video & Speed Check (15 min):** Students review concise background slides on Karen displacement, watch a short video by a Karen youth, complete a timed 6-statement True/False check on rolling whiteboards, and send volunteers up to write the answers directly on the projected screen for David Dollars.
- **5. Task 2: Empathy Role-Play Script Writing & Staging (25 min):** Teams receive a real Karen profile and take on the counterpart roles of American peers or neighbors. After watching a live teacher model with a neutral character, groups write an original

10-line dialogue on rolling whiteboards and rehearse their physical acting under a 20-minute timer.

- **6. Whole-Class Performances & Language Recasts (10 min):** Groups perform their 30-to-45-second scenes in front of the class, followed by teacher praise for empathetic ideas and quick, constructive grammar recasts on the board.
- **7. Closing: Exit Ticket, D\$ Raffle & Padlet Homework (5 min):** Students write a one-sentence reflection on the back of their David Dollars about starting over in a new country, enter the candy/sticker raffle, and receive their Padlet cultural food homework assignment.

RATIONALE & PEDAGOGICAL APPROACH

This 90-minute lesson serves as the centerpiece of a multi-week unit on *Intercultural Connection and Communication in America*. Grounded in the core classroom tenet that "*Communication is not just grammar; it is connection*," my instructional approach intentionally minimizes Teacher Talk Time (TTT) in favor of high-energy, student-centered output. Rather than remaining seated for passive lectures, students are up and moving across multiple phases of the lesson by shuffling partners through randomizer tools, collaborating at rolling whiteboard stations, walking to the board for interactive voting, and engaging in movement-driven speaking routines.

To ensure complete clarity and lower communicative anxiety for intermediate L2 learners, **the teacher explicitly models every single physical and communicative action before students begin**. From taking a sticky note and sticking it into a projected quadrant, to dividing paper clips into cups, writing target answers on mini whiteboards, and passing the ball in Hot Potato, every task is preceded by a fast, live visual demonstration.

Drawing on Berry's (1989) acculturation framework, specifically the distinction between integration, assimilation, and marginalization, this lesson engages learners in a two-directional empathy exercise. Students examine real-world challenges faced by Karen refugees resettling in Milwaukee, while simultaneously stepping into the shoes of local Americans to negotiate supportive, practical solutions. Frequent rotation of peers and roles ensures every learner builds collaborative speaking confidence and active social investment before traveling abroad.

CLASSROOM ROUTINES & MOTIVATIONAL MECHANICS

- **Wheel of Names / Picker Wheel (Dynamic Grouping):** To eliminate social friction and encourage wide social networks across the cohort, team formations and "Team Captain" designations are randomized using the digital Picker Wheel. Shuffling groups multiple times throughout the class keeps energy high, prevents clique formation, and ensures students practice communicating with a diverse range of peers.
- **Hot Potato Routine (Low-Anxiety Turn-Taking):** Instead of cold-calling or relying on rock-paper-scissors (*janken*), turn-taking is driven by "Hot Potato". Students pass a soft

foam ball while trading functional English phrases (e.g., *"Hey, what have you been into lately?"* / *"I've been into..."*) until the timer chimes. This gamified routine injects humor, builds spontaneous speaking fluency, and turns public speaking into an active, celebrated event.

- **David Dollars Token Economy & Exit Ticket:** David Dollars provide immediate positive reinforcement to keep students speaking 100% English, taking communicative risks, and actively helping their peers. I have used this reward system for years with first-year university immersion students because it consistently lowers communicative anxiety, and students love competing for and collecting them. At the end of class, the bills double as reflective exit tickets entered into a raffle for American candy and stickers.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Students will be able to:

- Describe who the Karen people are and explain the push factors leading to displacement from Myanmar.
- Analyze resettlement barriers (language, employment, isolation) faced by newcomer populations in the U.S.
- Apply Berry's concept of integration by taking on counterpart roles and writing collaborative action plans.
- Express complex personal decisions and empathetic reasoning using 100% English across dynamic paired and group rotations.

MATERIALS & SUBSTITUTE SETUP CHECKLIST

- **Slide Deck & AV:** Projector connected to Google Slides deck (with embedded 1:00 and 20:00 timers).
- **Stationery per Pair:** 4 distinct colors of sticky notes (for Warm-Up).
- **Stationery per Group of 4:** 4 plastic cups labeled *WAR*, *DISASTER*, *JOB*, *EDUCATION*, 40 paper clips (10 per student), dry-erase markers, and 1 rolling whiteboard.
- **General Class Supplies:** Mini whiteboards, dry-erase markers, 1 soft foam ball for Hot Potato, stack of printed David Dollar bills, raffle prizes (American candy and stickers).
- **Digital Links:** Digital Picker Wheel app tab and class Padlet board link.

90-MINUTE DETAILED PROCEDURE BREAKDOWN

1. Warm-Up: The "What is Real Connection?" Board Walk (10 Minutes)

- **Visual Hook (Slide 1–2):** As students walk in, project the 4-quadrant visual slide featuring diverse group work, a community picnic, a crowded subway, and an immigration paperwork desk.
- **Prompt (Slide 2):** Ask the class, "*What does REAL CONNECTION look like? (2 David Dollars!)*" Explain that moving to a new country can feel lonely or like community, and today we explore connecting through English.
- **Teacher Modeling:** The teacher holds up a colored sticky note, writes an example word ("*Teamwork*"), walks up to the projected whiteboard, and presses it into Quadrant A (*Community*) to demonstrate the physical movement and format.
- **Group Formation & Sticky Task (Slides 3–5):** Spin the Picker Wheel to form pairs. Give each pair 4 colored sticky notes. Partners write 1 word or short phrase for each quadrant:
 - *Quadrant A (Top-Left): Community* (e.g., *teamwork, working together*)
 - *Quadrant B (Top-Right): Connection* (e.g., *friendly, picnic, sharing*)
 - *Quadrant C (Bottom-Left): Alone / Isolated* (e.g., *lonely, quiet subway, lost*)
 - *Quadrant D (Bottom-Right): Confused* (e.g., *hard paperwork, no English*)
- **Board Walk (Slide 6):** Start the 1:00 timer. All pairs walk to the front and stick their colored notes directly onto the projected slide images on the whiteboard wall.
- **Debrief:** Teacher reads 2 or 3 standout notes, hands out David Dollars, and highlights: "*Communication is not just grammar; it is connection!*"

2. WALT & Framing (5 Minutes)

- **Goal Setting (Slide 7):** Project the WALT slide (100% English, problem-solving, understanding Karen displacement, empathy, and making cross-cultural friends).
- **Why This Matters (Slide 8):** Explain that students will travel to America soon and want to be welcomed, while Japan's multicultural society is also expanding.

3. Task 1: "Would You Leave Japan?" Decision Game (20 Minutes)

- **Group Shuffle & Material Pickup (Slides 9–10):** Spin the Picker Wheel to make new groups of 4 and designate the first student as the **Team Captain**. Captains walk up to collect 4 labeled cups (*War, Disaster, Job, Education*) and paper clips (10 clips per student).

- **Teacher Modeling (Slide 11):** The teacher projects the 4 scenarios and demonstrates the clip-voting rules with 10 sample clips:
 - *Rule 1:* Put at least 1 paper clip in every cup.
 - *Rule 2:* Maximum 7 clips in any single cup (no putting all 10 in one cup!).
 - *Teacher Demo:* 1 in Education, 1 in Disaster, 1 in Job, and 7 in War.
- **Deliberation & Voting (Slide 12):** Teams discuss the 4 life scenarios in English for 3 minutes and drop their clips into the cups.
- **Tally & 2-Minute Speech Prep (Slide 13):** Captains dump and count the clips to see which category won. Teams have 2 minutes on their feet to prepare a designated member to explain their top choice.
- **Hot Potato Share-Out (Slides 14–15):** Teacher models the Hot Potato routine (*"Hey, what have you been into lately?" / "I've been into..."*). Students toss the ball around the room until the timer sounds. The student holding the ball gives their team's 45-second speech (awarded 2 D\$).
- **Concept Bridge (Slide 16):** Tie the winning reasons back to reality: *"Unlike our game, Karen people did NOT have a choice; they were forced to leave due to war"*.

4. Input: Karen Background & Video Case Study (15 Minutes)

- **Context & Photos (Slides 17–21):** Walk through concise background slides showing Karen geography (Myanmar border/Thailand), refugee camp conditions, UN resettlement, and real photo archives from Milwaukee community events.
- **Video Case Study (Slide 22):** Play the short video narrative created by a Karen student in America.
- **Teacher Modeling (Slide 23):** Teacher shows a mini whiteboard to model writing *T* or *F* clearly for statements 1 to 6.
- **Whiteboard Speed Check (Slide 23):** Pairs consult on the 6 statements on Slide 23 and write **T** or **F** on their mini whiteboard within 1:00.
- **Hot Potato Board Run (Slide 24):** Use a rapid Hot Potato pass to call 6 students to the front to write **T** or **F** with dry-erase markers directly next to each sentence on the projected board (each volunteer earns 1 D\$). Confirm answers (1, 3, 5, and 6 are True).

5. Task 2: Empathy Role-Play Script Writing & Staging (25 Minutes)

- **Group Shuffle (Slide 25):** Spin the Picker Wheel to form fresh groups of 4 and assign rolling whiteboards.
- **Identity Profiles (Slide 26):** Project the 4 Karen identity profiles (*Eh Kler, 38, mother; Law Mu, 50, father; Dee Ku, 16, trans youth; Moo Shee, 13, middle schooler*) and their assigned American counterpart roles (*neighboring mother, construction worker neighbor, high school peer athlete, 20-year-old student-teacher*).
- **Teacher Modeling (Paw Lu Example, Slide 27):** The teacher calls up a student volunteer and performs the neutral Paw Lu art student dialogue live to demonstrate the required structure (Compliment → Shared Challenge → Relational Solution) and physical gestures.
- **Collaborative Script Writing (Slide 28):** Each group picks 1 Karen profile. Two students play the Karen newcomers and two play the American counterparts. Groups write a **10-line dialogue** directly on their rolling whiteboard.
- **Rehearsal with 20:00 Timer (Slide 29):** Start the 20:00 timer. Groups spend 12 minutes drafting their script and 8 minutes standing up rehearsing physical staging, eye contact, and vocal delivery. Teacher circulates, giving language feedback and awarding D\$ for 100% English immersion.

6. Whole-Class Gallery Share & Language Recast (10 Minutes)

- **Role-Play Performances (Slide 30):** Teams stand beside their rolling boards and perform their 30-to-45-second scenes for the class.
- **Debrief & Recasts:** Teacher praises specific empathetic solutions (e.g., offering bus guidance, sharing home recipes, inviting to soccer practice) and models brief language recasts on the board for grammatical clarity.

7. Exit Ticket, David Dollar Raffle & Padlet Homework (5 Minutes)

- **Teacher Modeling (Slide 31):** Teacher demonstrates flipping over a David Dollar bill and writing an example response on the back.
- **Exit Ticket Question:** *"What do you think would be the hardest thing about starting over in a new country with no money and little language ability?"*
- **Raffle Drawing:** Students write their names and reflections on their bills and submit them to the raffle bin. The teacher pulls 3 winning tickets for American candy and stickers.
- **Homework Assignment on Padlet:**
Post a picture of a traditional Karen dish you want to try.
Write 1 or 2 sentences explaining why you want to try it.